

Utah - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-30 Power 4 team with top-20 upside, but a complete offensive-line rebuild creates a much lower floor than the 11-2 record suggests
Preseason consensus	AP No. 21 (304 points) · SP+ No. 30
Returning production	55% (No. 55) overall · Off. 55% (No. 63) · Def. 55% (No. 55)
Primer power rating	+10.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	8.0 wins · most likely 8-4
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse, primarily because an elite 2025 offense loses its entire starting line and the program changes head coach/offensive coordinator
Confidence	Medium

2026 identity: Utah should still be quarterback-driven around QB Devon Dampier and RB Wayshawn Parker, with Kevin McGiven preserving QB-run/RPO flexibility while giving Dampier more pre-snap control, but the offense must rebuild every 2025 starting OL spot.

Bottom line: Utah remains a credible Big 12 contender because Dampier, Parker and the defensive system survive, but expecting another 11-win season requires a brand-new offensive line and several replacement defenders to hit quickly enough to preserve the efficiency that made the 2025 team elite.

Beats expectations if: The new OL reaches above-average efficiency, QB Devon Dampier's added pre-snap control preserves explosiveness, and the defense replaces DE Logan Fano, LB Lander Barton and secondary losses without leaking more big plays.

Disappoints if: The seven-man OL competition never produces a cohesive five, the new receiver order is inconsistent, and defensive turnover turns last year's already vulnerable explosive-play prevention into a major problem.

Five things to remember

- 1 QB stability:** QB Devon Dampier is the established returning QB1 and is being given more pre-snap protection/audible responsibility in Kevin McGiven's offense.
- 2 Offensive line:** Utah replaces all five 2025 starting offensive linemen, including first-round OTs Spencer Fano and Caleb Lomu.
- 3 2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense was genuinely elite: EPA/play No.8, success rate No.11, explosive-play rate No.16 and havoc allowed No.14.
- 4 Coaching:** Morgan Scalley is the new internally promoted HC, Kevin McGiven is the new external OC and supported offensive play caller, and Colton Swan is the internally promoted DC.
- 5 ? Key uncertainty:** CB Blake Cotton is a material Utah loss with a Denver NFL opportunity followed by an Aug. 20 college-portal re-entry, but his destination and settled eligibility remain unresolved.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	11-2 (7-2 Big 12)	● Excellent
Scoring	41.3 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	482.9 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	266.3 YPG · 6.0 YPC	● Elite
Pass efficiency	7.55 YPA · 27 TD / 5 INT	● Very good
Third downs	52.6%	● Elite
Scoring defense	18.9 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	359.0 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	181.2 YPG · 4.8 YPC	● Poor
Pass defense	177.8 YPG · 6.01 YPA · 12 TD allowed	● Elite

Utah won with a dominant offense built on elite rushing, scoring and third-down conversion. The defense was far more polarized: excellent against the pass, but vulnerable enough against the run to keep it from being a complete unit.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+10.55 · No. 8	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.232 · No. 8	● Elite
Off. success rate	49.4% · No. 11	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	14.9% · No. 16	● Very good
Havoc allowed	11.8% · No. 14	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+6.53 · No. 19	● Very good
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.107 · No. 24	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	37.7% · No. 25	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	12.8% · No. 90	● Below average
Havoc created	17.2% · No. 34	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Utah’s 2025 offense was not just high-scoring-it was elite on an opponent-adjusted and play-level basis, with top-16 marks in EPA, success, explosiveness and havoc allowed. The defense was also strong in efficiency but leaked too many rushing yards/explosives.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Morgan Scalley - internal promotion from DC/Safeties	● ↔ Preserves Utah’s identity, with first-year HC transition risk
OC / play-caller	◆ Kevin McGiven - from Utah State OC	● ↔ Inherits QB/RB strength but must install behind a rebuilt line
DC/LB	◆ Colton Swan - internal promotion from LB coach	● ↔ Internal continuity should preserve terminology and philosophy

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ WR Braden Pegan	Utah State	● ↑ Biletnikoff watchlist transfer projects as a major target and helps replace lost skill-position production.
◆ WR Kyri Shoels	San José State	● ↔ Adds another major-rotation receiver to a deeper but unsettled target group.
◆ OL Cedric Jefferson	Montana State	● ↔ Immediate first-unit OL competition is valuable, but no newcomer is treated as an automatic replacement for the five departed starters.

Out	To	Loss
OT Spencer Fano	NFL (Cleveland), Round 1, No. 9	● ↓ First-round starting-tackle loss and the highest-value piece of a complete OL rebuild.
OT Caleb Lomu	NFL (New England), Round 1, No. 28	● ↓ The other first-round starting-tackle loss removes the opposite bookend from an elite 2025 offense.
C/OG Jaren Kump	NFL (Chicago), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Starting center/guard experience leaves with the rest of the 2025 line.
OG Tanoa Togiai	NFL (Washington), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Starting-guard experience also departs for professional football.
OL Michael Mokofisi	Undrafted; NFL tryout/workout path	● ↓ Fifth 2025 starting OL loss; professional pursuit is without overstating a roster destination.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Clearly worse despite QB Devon Dampier/RB Wayshawn Parker continuity because the entire starting OL and a material TE are gone

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Jamal Wallace	Tennessee	● ↔ Veteran interior addition projected for a major role in the rebuilt front.
◆ DE Ethan Day	North Texas	● ↔ Adds edge rotation volume after DE Logan Fano and DE John Henry Daley depart.
◆ CB James Chenault	South Florida	● ↔ Projected major corner role in a secondary replacing multiple contributors.
◆ S Marcus Wimberly	Oklahoma	● ↔ Provides safety/DB experience next to returning S Jackson Bennee.

Out	To	Loss
DE Logan Fano	NFL (Cleveland), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material defensive-end loss from a front that must preserve 2025 efficiency.
LB Lander Barton	NFL (L.A. Chargers), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful linebacker loss despite LB Johnathan Hall's return.
DB Smith Snowden	Michigan	● ↓ Major secondary-role transfer loss.
DE John Henry Daley	Michigan	● ↓ Another meaningful front-seven departure.
DB Tao Johnson	UCLA	● ↔ Defensive-back turnover that raises newcomer dependence in the back end.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Worse and more newcomer-dependent, with internal defensive coaching continuity helping offset major front-seven and secondary departures

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	McGiven offense built around QB Devon Dampier's legs, decisions and added pre-snap autonomy.	QB Devon Dampier and RB Wayshawn Parker return from an elite efficiency/explosiveness offense.	Every 2025 starting OL spot is open, forcing the same engine to work behind an entirely new five.
Defense	DC Colton Swan continues Utah's established system.	Strong 2025 EPA/success-rate defense and internal staff continuity.	Run defense and explosive prevention were vulnerable before DE Logan Fano, LB Lander Barton and multiple DBs left.
Special teams	Punter settled, kicker unsettled.	The returning punter is established.	Placekicker remains an open competition and the baseline is near neutral.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A-	● ↔	High	QB Devon Dampier is the established high-end starter and bridge into OC Kevin McGiven's system.
RB	● B+	● ↔	High	RB Wayshawn Parker returns as a proven lead option after a 981-yard 2025 season.
WR	● B+	● ↑	Medium	WR Mana Carvalho and WR Braden Pegan give the new offense multiple high-upside targets.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	The room loses proven 2025 production and enters 2026 with less established impact.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	All five 2025 starting spots are open, making line cohesion the offense's defining uncertainty.
DL/Edge	● B	● ↓	Medium	DE Lance Holtzclaw returns, but major front departures reduce proven disruption.
LB	● B	● ↓	Medium-high	LB Johnathan Hall anchors the group after a major professional departure at linebacker.
Secondary	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	S Jackson Bennee provides continuity, but several major contributors departed.
Special teams	● C+	● ↔	Medium	Punter is settled, while the kicker job remains unsettled.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium	Internal promotions preserve Utah's identity, but HC/OC role changes add transition risk.
Overall	● B+	● ↓	Medium	A strong QB/RB core keeps Utah good, but OL and defensive turnover lower the 2025 ceiling.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Devon Dampier	QB	● High-end Power 4 starter / conference-impact quarterback	Maxwell · Walter Camp POY	The established starter is the bridge between the elite 2025 offense and McGiven's new system, with added pre-snap control.
Wayshawn Parker	RB	● High-end conference starter	Maxwell	Returns after 981 rushing yards and six TD and gives the rebuilt line/offense a proven backfield constant.
Mana Carvalho	WR	● High-end conference starter projection	Big 12 1st team	Big 12 first-team recognition matches his projected major role in an unsettled receiver order.
◆ Braden Pegan (TR: Utah State)	WR	● High-upside major-role transfer	Biletnikoff	A key newcomer expected to carry major receiving volume in McGiven's offense.
Johnathan Hall	LB	● High-end conference defender	Bednarik	Returns as the main linebacker/defensive leadership anchor after Lander Barton's pro departure.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Jackson Bennee	S	● Versatile major-role safety/returner	Paul Hornung	One of the most stable returning pieces in a secondary replacing multiple contributors.
Lance Holtzclaw	DE	● Solid Power 4 returning edge anchor	-	His returning presence is important after Logan Fano and John Henry Daley leave the front.
Alex Harrison	OL	● Projected OL organizer in an open competition	-	He is the highest-confidence candidate in a seven-man first-unit pool replacing every 2025 starter; the line's outcome is Utah's defining 2026 variable.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable for an eight-win/top-30 team: Utah avoids an extreme SOS.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 64
Hardest stretch	Houston -> at Cincinnati -> BYU -> at Arizona -> at TCU
Swing games	Arkansas, Houston, BYU, at Arizona, at TCU
Advantage	Three straight home games open the season, the bye follows the first road trip, and several mid-tier Big 12 opponents sit below Utah in SP+.
Expected	8.0 wins · most likely 8-4
Floor / ceiling	6-6 / 10-2

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Utah's 11-2 record and AP No.21 ranking can invite continuity assumptions, but SP+ No.30 and 55% returning production better capture the turnover risk.
Back them when	Against teams that cannot exploit a new OL with pressure and when Utah's QB-run/RPO game can force favorable numbers, especially if the line has settled by conference play.
Fade/pass when	Against disruptive fronts early, or against explosive offenses if the rebuilt secondary/front seven is still allowing the big plays that were a 2025 defensive weakness.
Key monitor	Final offensive-line five, kicker winner, WR target hierarchy, CB Blake Cotton destination/eligibility, secondary rotation, live Week 1 market
Week 1 baseline	vs. Idaho: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Utah -33.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Utah still has a contender's core in QB Devon Dampier, RB Wayshawn Parker and a defense retaining its system under DC Colton Swan. The offense should keep its QB-run/RPO flexibility, but every 2025 starting OL job has changed hands.

That line rebuild, plus meaningful defensive turnover, makes eight wins a sturdier baseline than another 11-win season. Utah has top-20 upside if the new five settles quickly and the defense contains explosive plays.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [2025 stats](#) · [transfers](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [position/camp update](#) · [Scalvey Tabs Kevin McGiven as](#) · [Colton Swan Promoted to Defensive](#)

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